

making, but a half-hearted attempt by his father to promote him as a child prodigy failed.

Travels to Vienna

Beethoven's family did not provide a secure emotional environment. His father was an unhappily married alcoholic who presided over failing family finances. But Beethoven nonetheless received plentiful support for his musical ambitions. The court organist, Christian Neefe, helped him with composition and arranged for his first work, *Nine Variations for Piano on a March*, to be published when he was only 12 years old. The archbishop elector sent Beethoven, aged 17, to Vienna to develop his talents. He probably took a few lessons with Wolfgang Amadeus Mozart before his mother's death brought him back to Bonn to handle the family's affairs as his father's condition deteriorated.

“What is in my heart must come out and so I write it down.”

LUDWIG VAN BEETHOVEN

Romantic influences

Working as a musician at the Bonn court for five more years, Beethoven was drawn into the cultured social circle around Helene von Breuning, the widow of a senior official. There he was introduced to the literary and philosophical ideas of nascent German Romanticism, with its belief in the transcendent value of art and the artist—a belief he